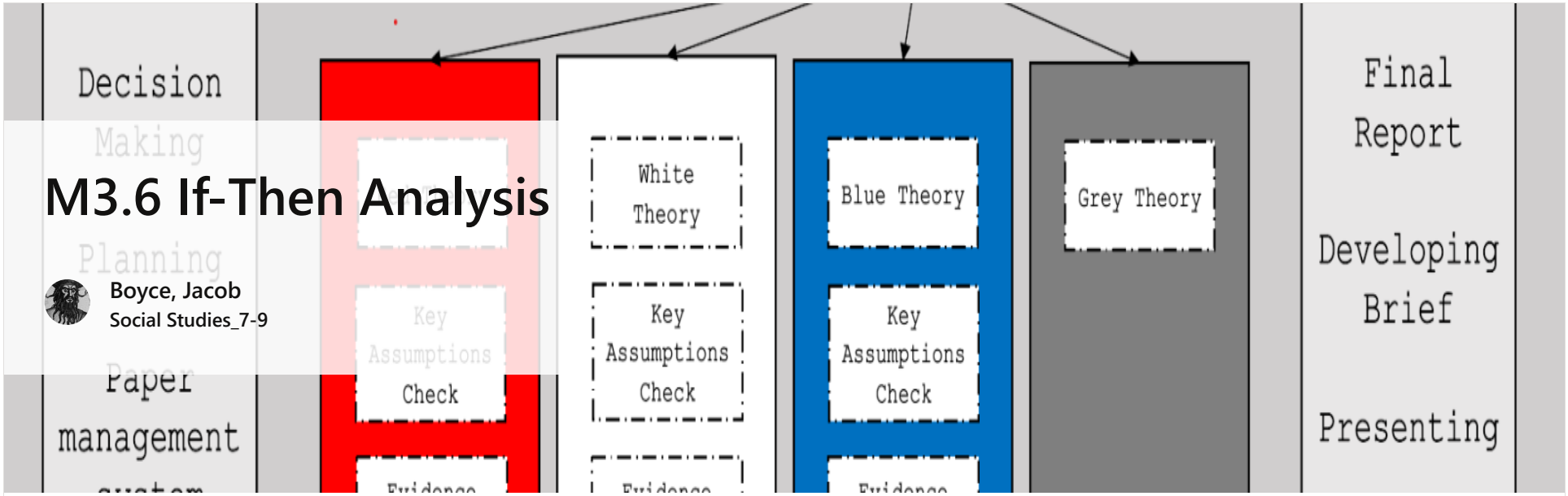
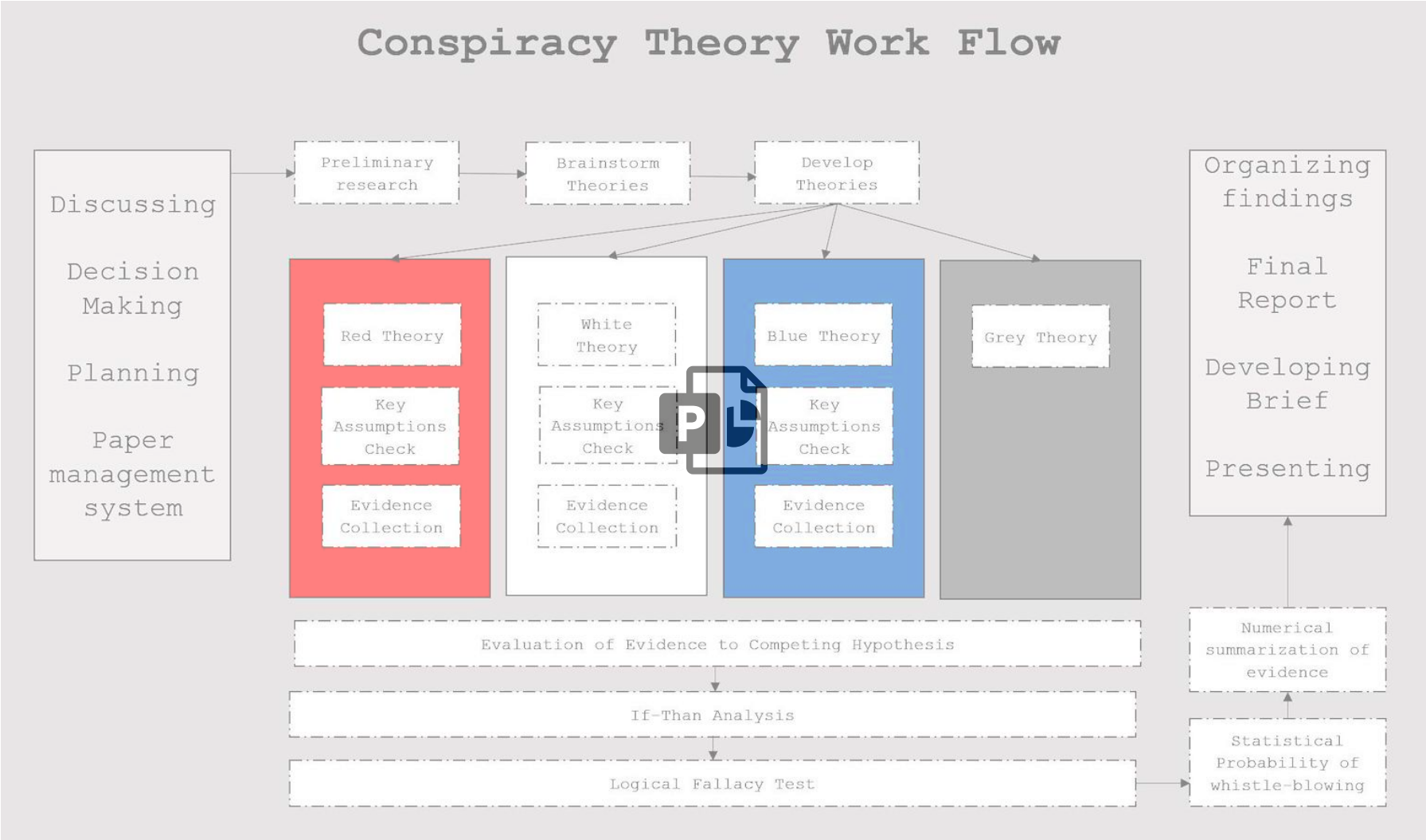


M3.6 If-Then Analysis

Boyce, Jacob
Social Studies_7-9

If Then Analysis

The If-Then Analysis is a structured analytical tool used to explore the implications of a hypothesis being true, focusing specifically on what additional facts or consequences must also hold true. This approach helps delve deeper into the plausibility of their hypotheses by examining the broader impacts and the necessary conditions that would arise if their initial assumptions are correct.



Episode 6 Skeleton

Episode 6 Example

Introduction

- **Objective**: Explore how misinformation and false assumptions have shaped decisions at different levels, from global policies to everyday school life.
- **Overview**: Misinformation (false information spread without harmful intent) and disinformation (deliberately deceptive information) both distort perceptions and influence decisions. We'll look at how these have been used throughout history to guide policies and laws, often with significant consequences.

Section 1: Historical Policies and Laws Guided by Bad

1. **Prohibition in the United States (1920-1933)**
    - **Detail**: Enacted through the 18th Amendment, based on the assumption that banning alcohol would reduce crime and corruption, improve health, and strengthen families.

- **Impact**: Instead led to a rise in organized crime, illegal speakeasies, and significant enforcement challenges.
- **Discussion Question**: Discuss how a failure to anticipate these consequences affected American society during and after Prohibition.

5. **The Marshall Plan**
   a. **Detail**: Post-World War II, the U.S. launched the Marshall Plan, which was based on the assumption that economic stability would prevent the spread of communism in Europe. This policy was grounded in the belief that poverty and economic instability were leading causes of the rise of extremist ideologies like communism.
   b. **Impact**: The plan successfully revitalized European economies and is largely credited with preventing the spread of communism westward, demonstrating a case where thorough analysis led to a positive outcome.
   c. **Discussion Question**: How did the accurate assumptions of the Marshall Plan's architects lead to its success? Could a flawed analysis have resulted in a different outcome?
6. **Iraq War (2003)**
   a. **Detail**: The decision to invade Iraq was significantly influenced by misinformation about the existence of weapons of mass destruction (WMDs).
   b. **Impact**: The absence of WMDs led to a long-term conflict with high human costs and destabilization of the region, which had global repercussions.
   c. **Discussion Question**: How could if-then analysis have better guided the decision-making process in the lead-up to the Iraq War?
7. **The Dred Scott Decision**
   a. **Detail**: In 1857, the U.S. Supreme Court's decision in Dred Scott v. Sandford was based on the assumption that African Americans could not be citizens and had no rights to sue in federal courts.
   b. **Impact**: This decision intensified national divisions over slavery and is considered a precipitating factor in the American Civil War.
   c. **Discussion Question**: What assumptions were made in the Dred Scott decision, and how did they reflect the societal beliefs of that era?
8. **Red Scare and McCarthyism**
   a. **Detail**: In the late 1940s and 1950s, U.S. domestic policy was heavily influenced by the fear of

communist infiltration, based largely on misinformation and exaggerated reports.
   b. **Impact**: Led to widespread paranoia, unjust persecution, and blacklisting of individuals in government, entertainment, and other sectors.
   c. **Discussion Question**: Discuss the effects of the Red Scare on American civil liberties. How could more critical analysis have altered the course of McCarthyism?
9. **Japanese Internment During World War II**
   a. **Detail**: Following the attack on Pearl Harbor, the U.S. government decided to intern Japanese Americans, based on the misguided belief that they posed a security threat.
   b. **Impact**: Over 100,000 Japanese Americans were forcibly relocated and interned, causing immense personal and economic loss, later recognized as based on racial prejudice rather than actual security risks.
   c. **Discussion Question**: Analyze the government's decision using if-then logic. What assumptions were flawed, and what were the consequences?

Section 2: Misguided Educational Policies and Rules

1. **Early School Start Times**
   - **Detail**: Based on the assumption that starting school early maximizes learning and aligns with parents' work schedules.
   - **Impact**: Research shows that early start times contribute to student sleep deprivation, affecting health, well-being, and academic performance.
   - **Student Activity**: Propose an alternative school schedule and predict its impact using if-then analysis.
5. **Zero Tolerance Policies in Schools**
   - **Detail**: Implemented with the assumption that severe, non-discretionary punishment for offenses would deter misbehavior.
   - **Impact**: Often resulted in disproportionately harsh punishments for minor infractions, affecting student futures.
   - **Discussion Question**: What unintended outcomes have these policies produced, and how could they have been anticipated?

Section 3: Real-World Application and Student Involvement

- **Group Activity**: Each group selects a current school rule or local law. Perform an if-then analysis to evaluate its potential or existing unintended consequences.
- **Discussion**: How might these insights apply to policy-making or rule-setting in your own school or community?

Section 4: Bringing it Closer to Home

- **Analogy to Middle School Dynamics**: How rumors and gossip, a form of misinformation, can distort perceptions and influence student interactions.
- **Example**: A student falsely accused of cheating faces social isolation, similar to how misinformation can tarnish reputations on a larger scale.
- **Discussion Question**: How do the dynamics of misinformation in middle school mirror larger societal issues?

Conclusion

- **Recap**: The dangers of incomplete analysis and misinformation can lead to widespread consequences in policies and personal lives.
- **Final Question**: How can you apply the lessons learned today to improve your approach to information and decision-making?